

iPhone 17

When Apple finally bridged the gap

There's a strange thing about being an iPhone user: for years, the regular iPhone has been the one you bought with your head, not your heart. It was the safe bet, the one that kept you in the ecosystem without making your wallet cry, but you always knew what you were missing. The smoothness of ProMotion, the extra lens, the kind of battery life that doesn't make you hover around chargers, those were reserved for the Pro crowd.

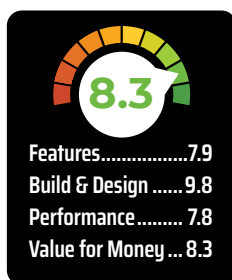
The iPhone 17 flips that script. This year, Apple hasn't just added a few features to justify an upgrade, it has quietly erased the invisible wall between the base and the Pro models. For the first time in years, the "default" iPhone feels like the one you actually want, not just the one you settle for.

DESIGN

At first glance, the iPhone 17 doesn't scream change. Same glass-on-glass sandwich, same aluminium frame, same neat Apple minimalism. But put it side by side with the iPhone 16 and the refinements start to stand out.

The display has grown from 6.1 inches to 6.3 inches, and that tiny 0.2-inch bump matters more than you'd think. Combined with slimmer bezels, the iPhone 17 feels fresh and more modern, with an impressive 90.1% screen-to-body ratio compared to the 86.8% of the iPhone 16. It's the kind of change you notice when you go back to the 16 and it suddenly looks boxed in.

The Ceramic Shield 2 on the front glass is now rated at Mohs level 5 hardness, making it about three times more scratch-resistant than last year's panel. Of course, it won't survive a drop straight onto concrete, but everyday wear and tear from keys, coins, and casual abuse feels less threatening.



It is slightly heavier (177g vs 170g on the iPhone 16) and marginally thicker (8mm vs 7.8mm), but in hand, that trade-off feels justified. The phone sits solid without ever really feeling bulky, and the weight balance is still pure Apple precision.

Waterproofing is unchanged (IP68), but this year's colour palette is where things feel fresh. Lavender, Sage, and Mist Blue give the iPhone 17 a personality the 16 lacked. The old Teal and Ultramarine shades were playful, yes, but they felt more "Gen Z accessory." The new tones are softer, calmer and I feel just more grown-up.

Apple didn't change the silhouette, but it made enough tweaks to it so that the iPhone 17 feels like the more premium object.

DISPLAY

This is the year the base iPhone finally graduates. The iPhone 17 gets ProMotion, the 120Hz refresh rate that's been locked behind the Pro models since 2021. And mind you, it's transformative. Scrolling feels fluid in a way that you can't quite describe until you go back to 60Hz, where suddenly everything feels sluggish, like you're dragging text through molasses. It's the single most important quality-of-life change Apple has made to the base iPhone in years.

The panel itself has also grown to 6.3 inches versus the 16's 6.1, with slimmer bezels that make the phone feel taller and more immersive. Resolution ticks up slightly too keeping the pixel density around 460 PPI, so sharpness is basically unchanged but still excellent.

Apple claims up to 3,000 nits peak brightness, but in our testing the iPhone 17 topped out at 1,820 nits in HDR content. That's still a healthy bump over the iPhone 16's 1,568 nits measured result, and more than enough to stay legible under harsh sun at noon. HDR videos on YouTube and Apple TV+ look fantastic, with highlights that pop without blowing out detail.

Colour accuracy is near perfect. The iPhone 17 continues to cover 100% of the sRGB spectrum with excellent calibration, meaning photos look true-to-life, not oversaturated. Paired with the adaptive ProMotion refresh and higher brightness, this screen feels every bit as "Pro" as the name implies.

PERFORMANCE

Apple silicon has always been fast enough to make benchmarks feel like bragging rights rather than necessities. It's the usual story with the iPhone 17: a modest CPU bump, a 5-core GPU, and stronger efficiency cores. The A19 has dedicated neural accelerators designed for the wave of AI features Apple is baking into iOS 26. So things like real-time photo retouching, transcriptions, and on-device Siri improvements all get the much-needed bump here.

On paper, the jump from the iPhone 16's A18 to the A19 looks healthy: